

up scientific instruments and collecting rock samples, but there was no serious pretence that the mission was about anything other than getting there and being there. The astronauts proudly planted the Stars and Stripes, offsetting this patriotic gesture with a plaque, attached to the leg of the lunar lander, expressing the noble sentiment: "We came in peace for all mankind." Like any tourists that have arrived somewhere interesting, they took photographs of one another, and they also phoned home – talking to President Richard Nixon through a special telephone link.

Having returned to the lunar module, the astronauts hooked up to the spacecraft's oxygen supply before shedding their backpacks and overshoes. The following day, after a sleep period, the launch back to the command module would take place. Igniting the engine on the module's ascent stage, they blasted off; the bottom half of the module – the descent stage – was left behind. The ascent stage then docked with the command module still in lunar orbit, reuniting Armstrong and Aldrin with Collins. The return journey to Earth, reentry to the atmosphere, and splashdown followed in textbook fashion. Apollo 11 landed in the Pacific off Hawaii 8 days, 3 hours and 9 minutes after the launch. The splashdown was some 10 seconds behind schedule.

Fears had been expressed before the mission that the astronauts might bring back with them Moon viruses or bacteria that would pose a threat to life on Earth, which would have no natural resistance to such alien infections. Consequently the Apollo 11 crew were transported to Houston in a sealed container, known as the Mobile Quarantine Facility. The rock samples they had collected were also quarantined. The astronauts were finally declared clear of contamination on August 10, and catapulted from confinement into a blaze of public exposure, including a traditional Broadway tickertape parade and an exhausting celebratory tour of 25 countries in 35 days.

Keeping the momentum

NASA had no intention of resting on its laurels. There were enough Saturn V boosters and Apollo spacecraft for nine more missions. Beyond that, there were visions of a permanent Moon base, a space station, and manned landings on Mars.

Yet masked by the temporary euphoria, difficulties were already mounting. Many American politicians were inclined to see the Moon landing as a culminating triumph, rather than a first step on the way to further projects. There was pressure to bring NASA's budget down as the American economy faltered and national finances suffered from the rising cost of the Vietnam War. The optimistic vision that had underpinned the space program through the



TRIUMPHANT HOME-COMING

After Apollo 11's punctual splashdown in the Pacific (left), Armstrong, Aldrin, and Collins were quarantined inside a sealed container, cramped quarters in which they received a visit from President Nixon (below). Their tickertape reception on a motorcade down Broadway (bottom) was one of the most enthusiastic on record.



1960s was becoming blurred in a growing national mood of doubt and self-criticism.

It did not help NASA's cause that the material brought back from the Moon proved short on the sort of excitement that makes headlines outside the scientific press. Certainly, the public lined up around the block to see Moon rocks displayed at the Smithsonian Institution in Washington, D.C. Equally certainly, geologists and astronomers found much to ponder and enlighten in the study of these rocks. But only traces of life could have supplied the drama that NASA desperately needed to hold public attention.

The first follow-up mission to the Moon, by Apollo 12 in November 1969, was another

